

On the eve of his departure for South Africa for the Champions Trophy, Sachin Tendulkar took time off for an exclusive interview with Deputy Editor SHARDA UGRA. Excerpts:

Q. You're embarking on your 20th year in international cricket, the only player after Gary Sobers to do so. Does it feel that long? Do you remember it all?

A. I remember on my first tour Kapil Dev challenged me. He said: "You play for ten years". When I completed ten years, Kapil Dev was the coach so I caught him and said I've won our bet. I'm glad today I'm almost very close to doubling that. I remember things clearly. I remember most of my dismissals and I don't think any cricketer forgets that... I remember the great shots too.

Q. What part of your 16 or 20 year old self would you like to have in your game today?

A. Mentally, it's different, now. When I was younger, there have been times when I've gone out thinking of attacking from ball one, that wherever the ball is I'm going to hit a six. That kind of thought process. But I'm glad that doesn't happen today. You think differently in various stages in life and you react accordingly.

Q. What is the single biggest lesson cricket has taught you, that would save a lot of younger guys a lot of trouble if they knew?

A. I think to respect the game and to respect fellow cricketers. I was made to realise that very early on. In the early years of cricket, you have done every possible thing under the sun to achieve your target. All of a sudden you have the India cap and India T-shirt and you start thinking, oh I'm somebody special. I remember just after I started to play for India, a close friend conveyed a message through another person: "Just tell him that I've noticed that he is probably starting to

think differently. The sooner he realises that, the better it is." And I sat back and I realised that, yes it was true and that really helped me. I normally tell the youngsters who just got in the team that it's good that you are here but learn to respect the cricketers who played with you before. That would help you to stay on the ground more than anything else.

Q. More than the runs or records, the consistency of your performance stands out in your career—what's the secret?

A. I don't know how to answer this. I wish I knew the answer, I've just gone out and played with a lot of passion and I spent a lot of time preparing my-

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self, not only physically but mentally. I spent time preparing. There have been ups and downs but when there are disappointments, I would much rather convert that negative energy into positive energy, in training harder or spending more time at the nets. The setbacks have motivated me. My thinking is simple, I want to convert those disappointments into positive energy and use it to get even more determined. That's what I've done, nothing else.

Q. They say as athletes get older their body starts to break down, give them trouble but their mind gets sharper about their game, they find

out new things. What are the kind of things you have learnt?

A. You discover a lot of new things and I've been able to do that. If earlier obviously there were just a couple of ways to deal with a particular bowler, then today there would be four ways. You just know how to use what and when. It's about not accepting every little challenge thrown at you and going after that. Sometimes you hold back and when it's needed you go for it. You just calculate better and it comes with age and experience.

Q. How much was opening the batting in one-day cricket a big factor in your success?

A. Yes, it was an important phase.

I remember in 1994, when Sidhu was not fit for an ODI game in New Zealand, I walked up to Azhar and Ajit Wadekar and told them 'give me one chance. I know I can hit the fast bowlers and if I fail, I will not come and ask you again.' They agreed and I scored 82 runs of 48 balls. From there on things started looking different for me.

Q. How?

A. Because I was consistently facing the new ball and playing the first spells. Also had to play shots, there was that freedom too. And while doing that, I thought I developed a few shots batting up the order, like the

punch off the backfoot and the short-arm pull. I used to play those but opening the batting, there was more opportunity to do that so I did and I started using that in Test cricket more than what I would earlier. The switch worked for me. To go out there and face the first spell and look to play shots... It was good for my game because I was always thinking positively.

Q. You say that you express yourself when you're batting, but you're not really an aggressive person?

A. I've always been competitive. It's extremely important for a sportsman to be highly competitive, one should not be able to take defeat just